A FIELD GUIDE

The Golden Sweet Potato.

Sweet enough to be dessert, tough enough to fuel a swim.



A small field guide for the house kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

We already know the potato. This is its sweeter cousin, a different plant altogether. It's cheap, it keeps for weeks, and it brings slow carbs, fiber and a mountain of vitamin A to the table. Before a swim it's fuel. After a row it's recovery. On a lazy night it's dessert with a little ginger syrup. You've bought it before, orange, purple and organic. Now we make it a regular. Let's get a stew going, baby.



SECTION I · MEET THE SWEET POTATO

The Family

- **Orange sweet potato:** moist, very sweet, deep orange inside. The vitamin A champion.
- **Japanese sweet potato (Beni Haruka and friends):** purple-red skin, pale gold flesh that turns sticky and honey-sweet when roasted slowly.
- **Purple sweet potato:** purple all the way through, drier and denser, with a nutty, less sugary taste. The color comes from anthocyanins, the same pigments as in berries.
- **White or yellow Thai sweet potato:** the everyday market kind, firm and mild, great in dessert soups.
- **Not a yam.** True yams are a different, starchier plant. And not a potato either: a sweet potato is a root, while a potato is a stem tuber from the nightshade family.



Names at the Thai Market

- **มันเทศ** (man tet): sweet potato, the general word.
- **มันหวาน** (man wan): "sweet tuber," what shops often call the sweeter Japanese types.
- **มันหวานญี่ปุ่น** (man wan yi-pun): Japanese sweet potato. **เบนิฮารุกะ**: Beni Haruka.
- **มันม่วง** (man muang): purple sweet potato.
- **มันเผา** (man phao): roasted sweet potato, the street snack.
- **มันต้มขิง** / **ต้มขิงมันเทศ**: sweet potato in ginger syrup, the classic Thai dessert soup.

(Names checked against Thai supermarket listings. Shop labels vary, so trust the skin and the cut face.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AND STORING

Reading the Signs

- **Firm and heavy** for its size. Soft spots mean rot is starting.
- **Smooth, tight skin.** Wrinkles mean it's drying out.
- **No mold, wet ends or deep cracks.** Small surface nicks are fine.
- **No sprouts,** or only tiny ones you can cut out.
- **Similar sizes** cook evenly, especially for whole roasting.



Keeping Them Sweet

1. **Cool, dark and dry, with air.** A paper bag or open basket away from the stove and the sun.
2. **Raw sweet potatoes dislike the cold.** Fridge chill can give them a hard core and an off taste, so keep whole raw ones out of the fridge when you can. In a hot Thai kitchen, buy what you'll eat in a week or two.
3. **Cooked sweet potatoes do belong in the fridge.** Cool, cover, refrigerate, and eat within about four days. Roasted halves freeze well for a month or two.
4. **Don't wash before storing.** Wash right before cooking.
5. **Cut pieces darken in air.** Drop them in water if they'll wait more than a few minutes.



SECTION III · PREP AND CUTS

Skin On, Mostly

Scrub well under running water with a brush. The skin is thin, edible and full of fiber, so keep it for roasting, wedges and stews. Peel for silky mash, dessert soups and anything you want smooth. A sweet potato is harder than a potato, so use a sharp, heavy knife and a steady board, and cut a flat side first so it can't roll.



Six Cuts

- **Whole:** for slow roasting and Instant Pot steaming.
- **Halves (lengthwise):** faster roasting, easy to stuff.
- **Wedges:** 6 to 8 per potato, the air fryer's favorite.
- **Cubes (2 cm):** for hash, stews, curries and congee.
- **Rounds (1 cm):** for the wok and the sous vide bag.
- **Batons (1 cm):** for fries. Soak 30 minutes and dry well.



SECTION IV · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time / temp
Wok stir-fry	1 cm rounds or small cubes	Medium heat, lid on 4–5 min with a splash of water, then lid off to brown
Instant Pot, whole	Medium potatoes on the trivet, 1 cup water	High pressure about 15–20 min, natural release 10 min *(estimate, depends on size)*
Instant Pot, stew	3 cm chunks	High pressure about 5–8 min with the rest of the stew *(estimate)*
Air fryer, whole	Pricked, skin oiled	**200°C for 35–45 min**, until syrup bubbles out
Air fryer, wedges	Wedges, light oil	**200°C for 15–20 min**, shake halfway
Air fryer, fries	1 cm batons, soaked and dried, a dusting of cornstarch	**190°C for 15–18 min**, shake twice
Air fryer, reheat	Leftover wedges or halves	**180°C for 4–6 min**
Sous vide	1 cm rounds or cubes, bagged with butter and salt	**185°F / 85°C for 1–1.5 hours** *(technique estimate)*
Steamed	Chunks	15–20 min until a knife slides in



Method Notes

- **Slow makes sweet.** Enzymes inside the sweet potato turn starch into sugar between about 60°C and 75°C. A long, gentle roast passes through that zone slowly, which is why a street-cart มันเผา tastes like honey. A fast microwave doesn't.
- **Wok:** Sweet potato burns before it softens. Steam it under the lid first, then let it brown.
- **Instant Pot:** Cubes go soft fast under pressure. Add them in big chunks or near the end.
- **Air fryer (Ninja Foodi):** One layer, a little space, light oil. The sugars brown quickly, so pull fries at golden.
- **Sous vide:** 85°C softens the root fully and the pieces keep their shape. Finish in a hot pan or the air fryer for color.



SECTION V · RECIPES

Street-Cart Roasted Sweet Potato (มันเผา, air fryer)

Scrub 2 medium Japanese sweet potatoes and prick them a few times. Rub with a few drops of oil. Air fry at **200°C for 35–45 minutes**, turning once, until the skin wrinkles and sticky syrup bubbles out. Rest 5 minutes. Eat as is, or split and top with a spoon of yogurt and a pinch of salt. Make extra: cold, they're tomorrow's pre-swim snack.



Ginger Sweet Potato Dessert Soup (มันต้มขิง)

Peel 300 g sweet potato and cut into 2 cm cubes. Simmer 1 L water with a thumb of sliced, bruised ginger for 10 minutes. Add the sweet potato and simmer 12–15 minutes until tender. Stir in palm sugar to taste, starting small, and a tiny pinch of salt. Serve warm. It's dessert and a warming drink in one, and it uses the ginger from your last chapter.



Sweet Potato and Black Bean Stew (Instant Pot)

On Sauté, brown 500 g boneless chicken thigh in pieces with 1 diced onion, 4 garlic cloves and a spoon of grated ginger. Add 400 g sweet potato in 3 cm chunks, 1 cup cooked black beans, 1 can chopped tomatoes, 1 cup stock, a spoon of fish sauce and a pinch of chili. High pressure **6 minutes** *(estimate)*, natural release 10 minutes. Stir in a handful of bok choy or spinach until wilted. Lime on top. About 4 portions; it keeps 4 days and freezes well.



Wok Sweet Potato with Egg and Garlic

Heat oil in the wok, add 250 g sweet potato rounds and a splash of water, and cover for 4–5 minutes. Uncover and let them brown. Push them aside, add 2 cloves sliced garlic, then 2 beaten eggs. Scramble softly into the sweet potato so the egg coats everything instead of standing alone. Finish with a dash of oyster sauce, white pepper and spring onion. The sweetness carries the egg, so the egg barely shows.



Congee Booster

Your morning congee wants color. Drop 100 g of small sweet potato cubes into the pot while reheating, cover and simmer 8–10 minutes until soft. Or stir in a few cubes of yesterday's roasted sweet potato at the end. You get extra carbs for the swim, fiber, and a day's vitamin A in the same bowl. Add an egg dropped in at the end if you're feeling brave.



Miso Butter Mash (sous vide)

Bag 500 g peeled sweet potato rounds with 1 tablespoon butter and a pinch of salt. Cook at **185°F / 85°C for about 1.5 hours** *(technique estimate)*. Mash in the bag or a bowl with 1 teaspoon miso and another small knob of butter. Silky, salty-sweet and perfect next to salmon or grilled chicken.



SECTION VI · PAIRINGS

Good Company

- **Bright:** lime, tamarind, chili, fish sauce, spring onion.
- **Warm:** ginger, garlic, cinnamon, black pepper.
- **Salty-savory:** miso, oyster sauce, soy sauce, a little cheese.
- **Rich:** butter, coconut milk, yogurt. A little fat helps your body absorb the beta-carotene.
- **Protein partners:** chicken thigh, pork, salmon, eggs, black beans, kidney beans.
- **Greens:** bok choy, kana, spinach, broccoli.



SECTION VII · NUTRITION

What's Inside

Per 100 g sweet potato, baked in its skin, no salt (USDA FoodData Central):

Nutrient	Amount
Energy	90 kcal
Carbohydrate	20.7 g
Fiber	3.3 g
Protein	2.0 g
Fat	0.15 g
Vitamin A	961 µg RAE (more than a full day's need)
Vitamin C	19.6 mg
Potassium	475 mg
Vitamin B6	0.29 mg
Manganese	0.50 mg
Magnesium	27 mg

A medium sweet potato is about 150 to 200 g, so multiply up.



The Honest Evidence Note

- **Vitamin A: strong evidence.** Orange sweet potato is one of the richest food sources of beta-carotene, which your body turns into vitamin A for eyes, skin and immunity. Orange-flesh varieties are used in public-health programs for exactly this reason.
- **Fat helps absorption: well supported.** Beta-carotene is fat-soluble, so eat it with a little butter, oil, coconut milk or yogurt.
- **Training fuel: sensible.** It's a whole-food carbohydrate with fiber and potassium, which fits around swims and rows like rice or potato does.
- **Blood sugar: it depends on cooking.** Studies find boiled sweet potato raises blood sugar much more gently than baked or roasted, which can rank high. Neither is "bad"; roasted is just quicker fuel.
- **Purple anthocyanins: early evidence.** Most findings come from lab and animal studies. Enjoy the color; don't expect miracles.



SECTION VIII · ROOTS AND MEMORY

The Traveler

The sweet potato was first grown in the tropical Americas thousands of years ago. It crossed the Pacific early; many researchers think Polynesian voyagers carried it home long before Europeans arrived. From there it reached China, Japan and Southeast Asia, and it became the food people leaned on when rice ran short. In Japan, trucks still sell stone-roasted sweet potatoes in winter. In Thailand, a charcoal drum of มันเผา on the roadside smells like evening. A humble root that has carried whole families through hard years. That's a teammate worth having.



SECTION IX · PRICES IN THAILAND

What It Costs

Where	What	Price
Freshket (house receipt, Nov 2025)	Purple sweet potato, 1 kg	฿58 / kg
Paleo Robbie (house receipt, Oct 2025)	Organic sweet potato, 500 g	฿89 (฿178 / kg)
Paleo Robbie (house receipt, Dec 2025)	Organic purple potato, 500 g	฿149 (฿298 / kg)
Lotus's online (checked Oct 2026)	Imported sweet potato	฿89 / kg
Lotus's online (checked Oct 2026)	PRIVE Japanese Beni sweet potato	฿199 / kg
Makro online (checked Oct 2026)	Japanese yellow sweet potato, 1 kg	฿89 / kg (on promotion from ฿99)
Makro online (checked Oct 2026)	Beni Haruka, 1.5 kg	฿249 (about ฿166 / kg)
Big C online (checked Oct 2026)	Japanese purple sweet potato	฿89 / kg

Per serving: a 200 g portion costs about ฿12 at the Freshket price or about ฿18 at ฿89 per kg. Online prices change often, so treat them as a snapshot.



Last Word

Cheap, sweet, patient in the pantry and generous on the plate. Roast a few on Sunday, and you've got fuel waiting all week. Now go get one in the fire.